Private School Universe Survey (PSS) 2023–24 Public-Use Readme File

A. Overview

The Private School Universe Survey (PSS) is conducted by the National Center for Education Statistics (NCES) on behalf of the U.S. Department of Education to collect basic information on American private elementary and secondary schools. PSS grew out of a proposal, in 1988, to develop a private school data collection that would improve the sporadic collection of private school data dating back to 1890 and improve commercially available private school sampling frames. PSS was first collected by the U.S. Census Bureau in the 1989–90 school year, with data collections every 2 years since.

The 2023–24 PSS instrument consisted of a single school questionnaire designed to be filled out by school administrators. Data collected included enrollment by grade, enrollment by race/ethnicity and sex, number of high school graduates, number of teachers, program emphasis, school religious orientation or affiliation, association membership, existence and type of kindergarten program, number of days in the school year and length of the school day, and whether the school had a library media center. For the 2023–24 PSS questionnaire, a question was added about virtual and hybrid schooling.

The data in this product release are for the 22,510 respondents to the 2023–24 PSS. The files only include the interviewed cases. Weighted counts can be obtained by running a statistical software application and using a "final weight" variable; see the user manual for details. The 2023–24 PSS data collection began in September 2023 and continued until June 2024.

B. Product Contents

Data Files

The data in this release are provided in three formats: SAS (*.sas7bdat); SPSS (*.sav); and a comma-delimited file that can be opened in any software that can import comma-delimited files of this size (approximately 39 MB). Each data file contains a unique record identifier, the Permanent Identification Number (PPIN). Variables on the data files fall into one of five categories: frame, survey, weighting, imputation flag, and composite variables, which are variables created from the questionnaire variables. The purpose of these categories is to help the user better understand what types of variables are included on the files and what the sources were for the variables.

Variables were classified as frame variables if they were drawn from the 2021–22 PSS file or based on the 2023–24 PSS frame update. Examples of frame variables include the school's permanent identification number (PPIN) and the ZIP code of the school's mailing address (PZIP).

Table 1. PSS 2023–24 Public-Use Data Files

File Name	File Description
pss2324_pu.csv	Public-use dataset in CSV format
pss2324_pu.sas7bdat	Public-use dataset in SAS format
pss2324_pu.sav	Public-use dataset in SPSS format
2023-24_PSS_Frame_Data.csv	Sampling frame dataset in CSV format

SOURCE: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, Private School Universe Survey (PSS), 2023–24.

Program Files

For the SAS and SPSS files, a corresponding label and format library is provided to apply the appropriate variable formatting. To open the data file in your selected statistical package, open and execute the corresponding format program. To use the format program, you must specify the correct path to the data file.

Table 2. PSS 2023–24 Public-Use Program Files

File Name	File Description
Create PU 2023-24 PSS SAS Dataset.sas	SAS program to read the CSV dataset into SAS
Create PU 2023-24 PSS SAS Formats.sas	SAS format statements to create SAS format library
Create PU 2023-24 PSS SPSS Dataset.sps	SPSS program to read the CSV dataset into SPSS

SOURCE: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, Private School Universe Survey (PSS), 2023–24.

Documentation Files

The documentation files listed in table 3 provide information about the PSS 2023–24 data collection and resulting data files.

Table 3. PSS 2023–24 Public-Use Documentation Files

File Name	File Description
2026035.pdf	User manual for the public-use product
2023-24_PSS_Frame_File_Data_Dictionary.pdf	Data dictionary for the frame dataset
Questionnaire2023_24.pdf	Survey instrument
Codebook2023_24.pdf	Codebook for the public-use dataset
Layout2023_24.pdf	Record layout for the public-use dataset
Readme2023_24.pdf	Overview document

SOURCE: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, Private School Universe Survey (PSS), 2023–24.